



Peripheral or not? Cinema of small countries in the programming of international film festivals

Vejune Zemaityte, Ulrike Rohn & Indrek Ibrus

To cite this article: Vejune Zemaityte, Ulrike Rohn & Indrek Ibrus (02 Dec 2025): Peripheral or not? Cinema of small countries in the programming of international film festivals, Cultural Trends, DOI: [10.1080/09548963.2025.2595105](https://doi.org/10.1080/09548963.2025.2595105)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/09548963.2025.2595105>



© 2025 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group



Published online: 02 Dec 2025.



Submit your article to this journal [↗](#)



View related articles [↗](#)



View Crossmark data [↗](#)

Peripheral or not? Cinema of small countries in the programming of international film festivals

Vejune Zemaityte , Ulrike Rohn  and Indrek Ibrus 

Baltic Film, Media and Arts School, Tallinn University, Tallinn, Estonia

ABSTRACT

Despite the increasing production capacities of small countries, their films struggle to reach international audiences. Festivals could help these productions achieve global exposure and secure distribution deals. Building on research on transnational film flows, small media markets, and film festivals, this article investigates power relations in the global film industry and assesses whether the smallness of production countries equates to their peripherality. It uses the Cinando database to empirically examine the representation of 170 countries in the programming of 578 festivals from 2009 to 2021. Findings suggest that the larger the country's population and wealth, the more likely its films will be featured in festivals. While small-population, wealthy countries are increasingly included, especially outside top-tier events, productions from less wealthy small-population nations remain overlooked. These results indicate that less populous countries, particularly those of lower incomes, remain peripheral in the film industry, with festivals failing to improve their global reach.

ARTICLE HISTORY

Received 25 July 2024

Accepted 20 November 2025

KEYWORDS

Film industry; film festivals; small countries; periphery; transnational film flows; big data

Introduction

As film production in small European countries increases due to growing audiovisual sectors (Ibrus & Rohn, 2019), its international reach remains constrained, often to domestic markets of the film's origin country (Hjort, 2007; Nielsen et al., 2024). These markets are considered peripheral or semi-peripheral, characterized by low film export rates and heavy imports from major media hubs like Hollywood (Curtin, 2009; Nielsen et al., 2024; Szczepanik, 2021). In this context, film festivals have emerged as vital platforms for gaining global visibility (Czach, 2004; De Valck, 2007; Harbord, 2002; Rohn et al., 2018; Rüling & Pedersen, 2010), particularly for films produced in smaller countries. While earlier accounts emphasized that most non-Hollywood productions gained international fame via the festival circuit (Thompson & Bordwell, 1994), recent scholarship highlights increasingly polycentric film industry shaped by emerging hubs like

CONTACT Vejune Zemaityte  vejune@tlu.ee;  <https://x.com/VejuneZem>,  Baltic Film, Media and Arts School, Tallinn University, Narva mnt 25, Tallinn 10120, Estonia  <https://www.linkedin.com/in/vejunezemaityte/>

© 2025 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group

This is an Open Access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>), which permits unrestricted use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited. The terms on which this article has been published allow the posting of the Accepted Manuscript in a repository by the author(s) or with their consent.

Nollywood, Bollywood, and East Asia, and by streaming and online distribution (Curtin, 2007; Krings & Okome, 2013; Lobato, 2018). Despite these shifts, festivals remain key to global film visibility and cultural legitimacy, warranting closer examination of how effectively they represent films from small countries.

Film festivals differ in size, budget, focus, and benefits for attendees (Burgess, 2020; Krainhöfer, 2018). A-list festivals, as classified by the International Federation of Film Producers Associations (FIAPF, 2023), stand at the pinnacle, renowned for their industry prestige. Showcasing quality films from global cinema, they attract top filmmakers, industry insiders, and the media spotlight. Cannes, Berlinale, and Venice exemplify such elite gatherings, where inclusion can significantly boost a film's global profile and benefit professionals from smaller nations by providing unparalleled exposure and networking opportunities. The significance of film festivals as cultural gatekeepers is widely recognized. Scholarly research has increasingly delved into the power dynamics within the festival landscape, exploring topics like cultural and geographical representation (Iordanova, 2009; Stringer, 2001; Thompson & Bordwell, 1994; Vallejo, 2020). Until recently, such research was limited to theoretical considerations (e.g. De Valck, 2007; Iordanova, 2009; Loist, 2016) and qualitative single case studies (e.g. Peirano, 2017; Sun, 2015; Vallejo, 2015), as Loist and Samoilova (2019) have pointed out. The first quantitative approach to film festival studies – the Film Circulation Project – leveraged festivals as tools for analyzing power relations in the global film industry and analyzed festival runs to study the significant role festivals play in film life cycles (Loist, 2023; Loist & Samoilova, 2023). We also adopted quantitative methodologies to analyze the power dynamics in the global film festival network in this work.

Unlike previous research, however, we conducted a big data analysis via a single database, eliminating the issues of data incompatibility and data integration complexities often encountered when merging different databases. Access to the Cinando database of *Marché du Film – Festival de Cannes*, which meticulously records activities from hundreds of festivals worldwide, enabled us to investigate the crucial issue of the representation of small countries in festivals, offering insight into the dynamics and power relations within the global film ecosystem. Our analysis considered 26,240 films programmed at 578 festivals during 2009–2021, representing 170 film-origin countries and 40 festival-host countries worldwide. We counted all instances when films were selected for festival programs, regardless of section, premiere status, or awards. As measures of smallness, we categorized film production countries based on population, considering nations with under 18 million inhabitants as small (Puppis, 2009), and gross national income (GNI) per capita, categorizing countries into low, lower-mid, upper-mid, and high income. To reflect the festival hierarchy, we divided our event sample into competitive A-list feature film festivals based on the FIAPF (2023) accreditation and a heterogeneous “other” group containing all remaining events.

International co-productions have grown in importance, particularly within Europe (Bondebjerg, 2016; Parc, 2020), prompting scholars to problematize the concept of national cinema in favor of transnational (Rawle, 2018) or global (Şavk, 2024) perspectives. While many films, particularly from countries with limited domestic infrastructure, are made through complex co-production arrangements involving multiple funding and creative partners, national-level analysis remains relevant, as funding and policy are still predominantly determined by national institutions, with festival access as an articulated

national policy goal. Our data supports this approach, as co-productions comprise only 29% of festival selections in our sample.

Our study examines whether small countries are peripheral in the global film industry, as reflected in their limited representation at festivals. In pursuing this, we expand on prior work on small countries and festivals, especially research linking small size to peripheral status (see also Szczepanik, 2021).

Theoretical background

Small countries in the global film industry

The representation of small countries at film festivals must be understood against evolving discussions on global media flows. Initially, the cultural imperialism thesis posited a core–periphery dynamic, with media flows directed mainly from the US to the rest of the world, highlighting its one-dimensional influence (Boyd-Barrett, 1977; Nordenstreng & Varis, 1974). This model has been challenged and refined by the notions of cultural globalization and hybridization (Kraidy, 2005), cultural discount (Hoskins & Mirus, 1988), and cultural proximity (Straubhaar, 1991), which explain audience preferences for local over foreign media (Rohn, 2009, 2011; Straubhaar, 2007). The concepts of counter-flows and contra-flows further enrich this discourse (Boyd-Barrett & Thussu, 1992; Thussu, 2006), as do perspectives that offer a polycentric view of world cinema, arguing against the linear dominance of any single culture (Goldstein-Gidoni, 2005; Nagib et al., 2012).

Despite the recognition of cinema’s interconnectedness and the emergence of multiple global centers, the predominance of US films in Europe is undeniable, as demonstrated by statistics and academic discourse (Crane, 2018; Nielsen et al., 2024). This dominance persists in the age of transnational online distribution (Lobato, 2018) and platform imperialism (Jin, 2017), with US content comprising 63% of ticket sales (Kanzler, 2023) and 49% of video-on-demand catalogue entries (Lacourt et al., 2023) in the EU in 2022. The conversation on cultural flows is regaining prominence, underpinning ongoing critiques of the imbalance in power between dominant media centers and their global audiences (Mirrlees, 2013; UNESCO, 2005; Winseck, 2011). International policy frameworks underscore the need to support underrepresented cultural sectors, especially in developing media industries (UNESCO, 2005). Recent data confirm that films from small countries struggle to reach global audiences (Nielsen et al., 2024). Given the importance of festivals for global visibility, a nuanced understanding of how small-country films are represented in programming is needed.

Previous research has examined the unique circumstances of media markets and dynamics in small countries within the framework of transnational flows and power negotiations. Since smallness is relational and contextual, a “small market” lacks a precise definition. However, population and economic size measures are used as fundamental in determining the economic situation of the industries in these markets (Szczepanik, 2021). Media industries in small markets face four key challenges: resource scarcity, limited domestic demand, dependency, and vulnerability (Puppis, 2009). These industries struggle to develop resources effectively due to a constrained pool of skilled labor (DeFilippi & Arthur, 1998) and face difficulties achieving economies of scale within their domestic markets. This places them at a cost disadvantage compared to larger countries (Lowe

et al., 2011; Rohn, 2014), affecting the viability of local producers. Moreover, small countries often rely on importing content, while cultural and linguistic differences hinder their export capabilities, further entrenching their dependency on larger markets and exposing them to external influences (Chung, 2011; Fu & Sim, 2010; Nielsen et al., 2024; Szczepanik, 2021; Tunstall, 2008).

Although film industries in small markets share similar constraints, their smallness does not necessarily equate to peripherality (Szczepanik, 2021). While considerable research presumes that globalization affects the media markets of small and large countries differently (Ibrus, 2016; Michalis, 2014; Puppis, 2009; Rohn & Loeser, 2020; Trappel, 2014), other work highlights the growth and international success of the audiovisual industries in some small countries (Ibrus & Rohn, 2019). For instance, the Danish film industry has become more central in transnational content flows (see also Hjort, 2015) compared to Poland, which, according to Szczepanik (2021), remains in a peripheral position in international film flows. The reasons why some small film markets thrive despite inherent challenges have been linked to linguistic, artistic, and institutional factors (Hjort, 2007), notably in Scotland (Murray, 2015), the United Arab Emirates and New Zealand (Leotta, 2015), and Singapore (Fong & Ng, 2020; MacPherson, 2011). The growth in Northern and Eastern European audiovisual industries has been credited to strategic policymaking, including innovation policies (Ibrus & Rohn, 2019). The appeal of Scandinavian audiovisual fiction is attributed to its unique aesthetics (Agger, 2016; Dunleavy, 2016), its production and financial models (Jensen et al., 2016; Redvall, 2018), and the global allure of Nordic noir, tied to its literary (Hansen & Waade, 2017) and cinematic (Jensen & Jacobsen, 2017) expressions.

Small countries and international film festivals

Festival curatorial practices are crucial in enhancing the visibility of films and shaping global film canons (Vallejo, 2020). Festival programmers act as cultural gatekeepers, contributing to the dissemination of cinematic knowledge (Czach, 2004) and influencing transnational dynamics in the global film industry through their selections (Iordanova, 2009). The programmers of the renowned A-list festivals, which showcase films from diverse cultural backgrounds, play a pivotal role in this regard (Iordanova, 2009). The festival gatekeeping function is fulfilled by facilitating international circulation, thereby determining the promotional avenues available to films from various regions, as the inclusion in programming can significantly impact the success of national film industries on the global stage (Wong, 2011), particularly in elevating non-Hollywood and non-Western films that originate outside dominant Western cultural and industrial contexts to international prominence (Stringer, 2001; Thompson & Bordwell, 1994). This is because festivals are important nodes for global business ventures, where distributors seek acquisition opportunities while producers establish transnational networks and forge collaborations with potential partners (Baltruschat, 2010; Palis, 2015; Wong, 2011). International co-productions, especially with well-connected partners, can enhance public support, production quality, and cross-border distribution (Jäckel, 2003; Talavera, 2017), with festivals playing a pivotal role in fostering these connections (Baltruschat, 2010; Rohn et al., 2018). International networking among film professionals

from smaller countries during festivals is, therefore, crucial for exporting success and industry advancement (Rohn et al., 2018).

Scholarly research has increasingly delved into power dynamics within the festival landscape, exploring issues like cultural hierarchies and geographic representation (Vallejo, 2020). Vallejo advocates for a deeper examination of programming and award practices at major festivals to better understand their role in shaping global cinema. Academic interest in festivals as objects of critical inquiry has grown, driven by their influence on the international visibility of films from non-hegemonic regions and the connectivity of industry professionals (Rohn et al., 2018; Vallejo, 2020). Given their profound impact on the film industry, festivals offer valuable insights into power relations within the global film landscape. However, despite their potential benefits for film industries in small countries, there is a remarkable lack of research examining the representation of small-country productions in festival programming.

Drawing on prior research concerning film festivals, small media markets, and international film industry dynamics, we utilized a sample of festivals defined by inclusion in the Cinando database and subject to program size thresholds to analyze power relations within the global film industry. We focused on the inclusion of films from small countries into festival programs as an indicator of their international visibility. Following previous research, which emphasizes that smallness should not be confused with peripherality (Szczepanik, 2021), our overarching research question asked: *To what extent can we say that small countries are peripheral in the global film market, expressed by low or non-representation in the programming of film festivals?*

Materials and methods

Festival programming data from Cinando

To address the overarching research question, our analysis employed film festival programming data (Zemaityte et al., 2023) from the Cinando database – a premier online platform that supports hundreds of festivals and markets – provided by Marché du Film – Festival de Cannes. As with any proprietary database, cleaning and data disambiguation were required (see Zemaityte et al., 2024). We also used a minimum program size criterion of 15 unique films (Krainhöfer, 2018) to select a festival sample since programs were often captured incompletely. The cleaned dataset contained information about the programming of 578 festivals held during 2009–2021 (including 28 one-time events and 550 events of 95 multi-event series), featuring 26,240 films via 35,248 film–festival instances. The festival data offer global coverage, with events held in 40 countries across all continents. Still, most events were hosted in the Global North (Figure 1A). The dataset features festivals with different programming agendas, including mainstream (i.e. Cannes, Berlinale), regional (i.e. Eurasia, Seville European), and thematically specialized festivals (i.e. CPH:DOX, Fantasia, Annecy, BFI Flare, Series Mania). For an in-depth analysis of festival types within the Cinando dataset, see Zemaityte et al. (2024). With this large dataset, our analysis promised a unique and nuanced understanding of power relations in the global film festival circuit.

Festival data included event and series titles, location country, and event year from Cinando. We further classified events within our sample as 14 competitive A-list feature

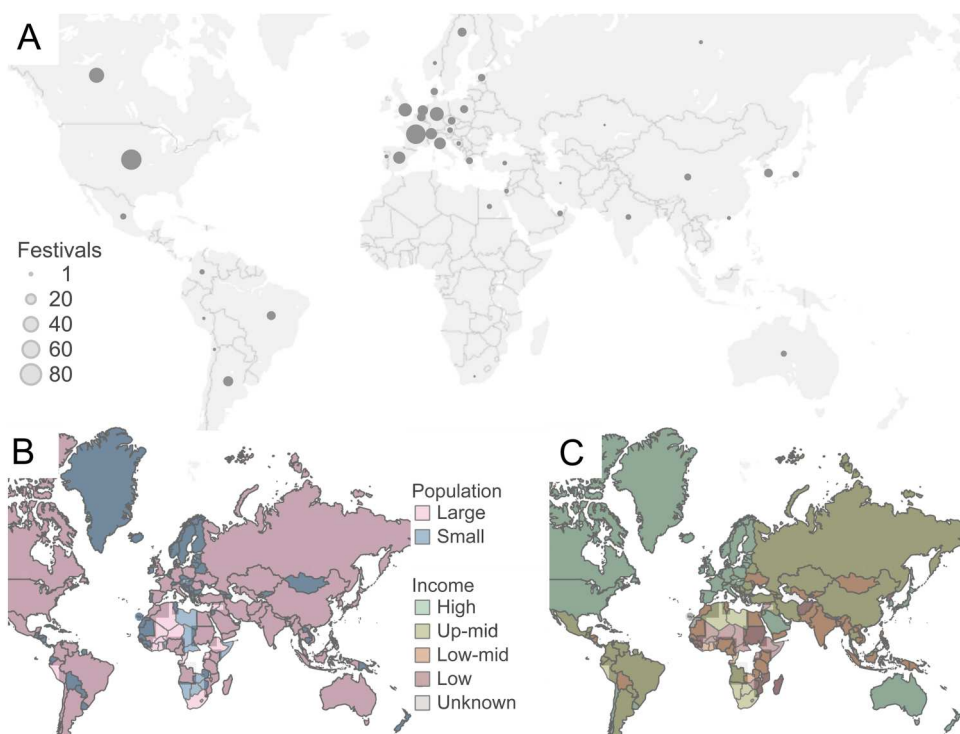


Figure 1. Festival locations and film production countries. (A) Festival host countries marked by circles sized by number of events. Production countries colored by (B) population and (C) income. Countries in co-productions were equally weighted.

film festivals¹ and a heterogeneous “other” festival group containing all remaining festival series ($N = 109$). While our grouping strategy aided analytical clarity, combining diverse festivals into a single “other” category may obscure differences in programming agendas, thematic specializations, or regional mandates. Future research should explore more granular classifications to address this heterogeneity. Although FIAPF grants the accreditation annually, we extrapolated the same grouping to all events in a series, like Cannes 2014 and Cannes 2015. Despite its global prestige, Sundance is not accredited (Roxborough, 2020) and was, therefore, grouped among other festivals in this article. While FIAPF’s strict accreditation criteria have been criticized in the industry (Fratr, 2007), we used the ranking as the industry’s quality and reliability standard.

The number of festivals on Cinando (which met our inclusion criteria of at least 15 films in programming) increased steadily during the beginning of the period, stabilizing from 2014 at around 60–70 yearly events (Figure 2A) and 4,000 festival selections (Figure 2B). Since this vast database growth might skew the observed trends, we reported annual statistics only from 2014 to 2021 but considered all available data in general observations. In contrast, the end of the period coinciding with the COVID-19 pandemic saw a sharp decrease in the number of festivals (Figure 2A) due to event cancellations driven by social distancing policies worldwide (De Valck & Damiens, 2023; Smits, 2023). However, some festivals moved online, which enabled them to expand programs, explaining the stable rate of festival selections during 2020–2021 despite there being fewer events

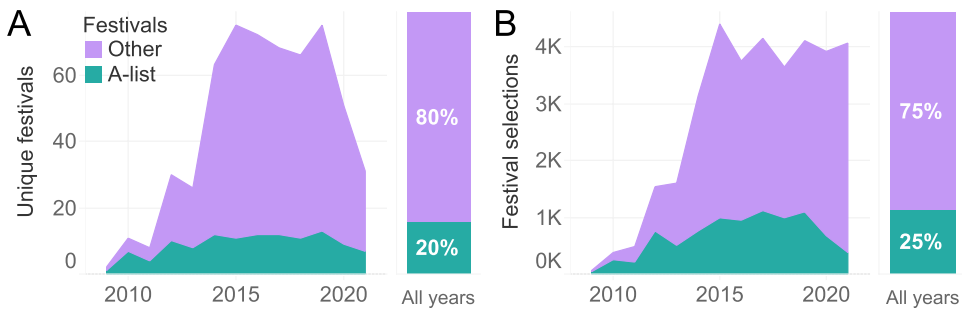


Figure 2. Festival dataset growth: (A) number of events and (B) festival selections, 2009–2021, colored by festival group (A-list or other).

(Figure 2B). Although our analyses considered data from the end of the period, any trends must be interpreted cautiously due to unique industry conditions. A-list festivals constituted 20% of events and 25% of festival selections in our sample (Figure 2). With the observed fluctuations primarily affecting the other festival group, the number of yearly A-list events remained relatively stable during the period (Figure 2A). Interestingly, during the COVID-19 pandemic, selections decreased at A-list festivals while increasing at other events (Figure 2B).

The data on films selected by festivals included production year and country from Cinando. Additionally, we classified films as produced in countries with small or large populations (Pelinka, 2005; Puppis, 2009). We used population size (World Bank, 2022) as a direct indicator of a country's media market size, reflecting the potential domestic audience, and as a proxy for the size of its professional film industry workforce, categorizing countries with fewer than 18 million inhabitants as small (Puppis, 2009). Future research might investigate more detailed country stratification by distinguishing between small and microstates (Puppis, 2009). We also categorized film production origins into low, lower-middle, upper-middle, and high income countries based on the GNI per capita, calculated using the Atlas method, and noted the yearly gross domestic product (GDP) of each country (World Bank, 2022, n.d.). A country's income level serves as a proxy for the domestic audience's spending power on film entertainment and the overall national investment in film production. A limitation of our dataset is the absence of direct measures of national film production industries, like the number of active production companies or annual film output, which we recommend future research consider.

To account for changes in population and income, we classified countries yearly according to the production year. We used the closest available statistics if the production year or statistics for the production year were unavailable.² Amounting to 29% of festival selections, co-productions within a population or income category were assigned to that category, creating a separate category for cross-category co-productions. The dataset included films from 170 origins, with a higher prominence of small population countries ($N = 106$ vs. 64), particularly in Europe and Africa (Figure 1B). Production countries in North America, Oceania, and most of Europe were primarily high-income, those in Latin America were upper-middle-income, and low to upper-middle income categories were assigned to Asia and Africa (Figure 1C).

Research questions and analysis method

Serving the overarching research question above, our longitudinal analysis of film festival programming was guided by the following sub-questions:

- What proportion of films selected for festivals comes from countries with different population sizes and income levels?
- How has this proportion changed over time?
- How does this proportion differ between the competitive A-list feature film festivals and other events?
- How do the country's population size and income relate to the festival selection rates for its films?

To understand the overall tendencies in festival programming, we counted the number of festival selections by production country group based on population, income, and a combination of both for the entire observation period (2009–2021). Next, we calculated the percentage of festival selections for different country groups during reliable yearly festival data (2014–2021) to examine how programming changed over time. To further reveal how programming differed between the competitive A-list festivals and other events, we compared their shares of festival selections for different country groups during the same period. The programming choices of several specific festival series were also examined to illustrate programming dynamics in more detail. Lastly, we conducted a correlation analysis to explore the relationship between festival selections and production country characteristics based on annual population and GDP (US\$). To account for yearly changes, we averaged population and GDP while summing festival selections for each production country during the observation period. For co-productions, each festival selection counted toward each production country equally. All variables were expressed in base-10 logarithms before the analysis to remedy skew in the data. The Pearson correlation coefficient measured the relationship strength.

Results

Festival programming by production countries

Our analysis of the Cinando data showed that most distinct film production countries with at least one film programed within our festival sample during 2009–2021 had a small population (62%, [Figure 3A](#)). However, films produced in large-population countries or co-productions between multiple large-population countries were selected for festivals nearly four times as often as films from small-population countries (17% of selections, including co-productions) or co-productions between countries with large and small populations (16% of selections, [Figure 3C](#)). The number of distinct production origins selected for festivals in our dataset at least once increased with the country's income bracket ([Figure 3B](#)). Most film origins had high income (34%), while the fewest had low income (14%). However, films and co-productions from high-income countries were selected for festivals disproportionately more often (70% of selections), with films from low-income origins almost completely overlooked (0.2% of selections, including low-income co-productions, [Figure 3D](#)). The difference between the selection rates for films

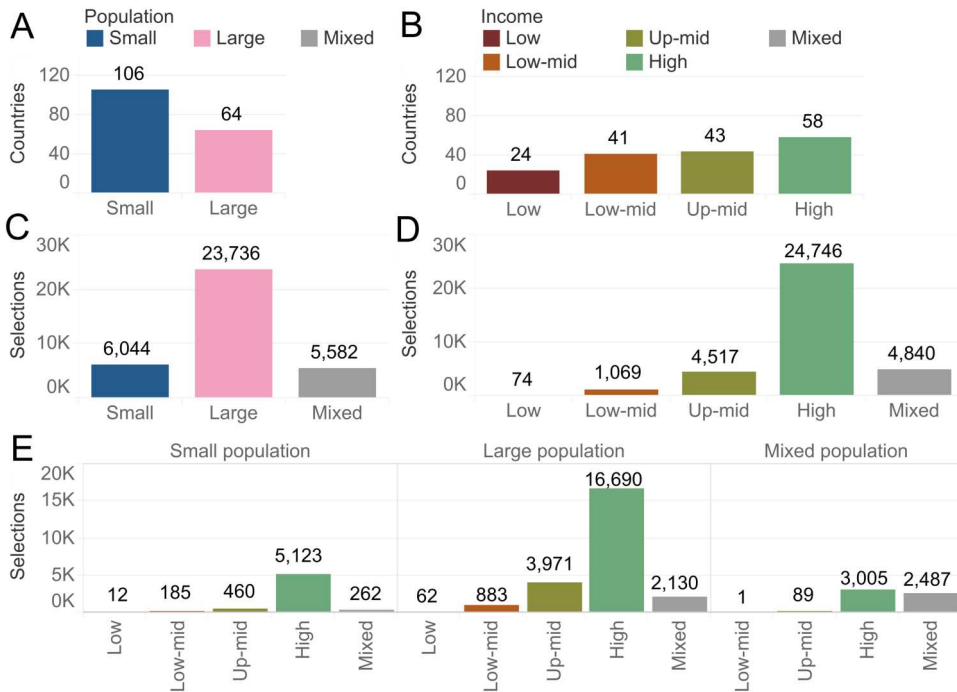


Figure 3. Distinct film production countries in festival programming (2009–2021) by (A) population and (B) income. Festival selections by (C) population, (D) income, and (E) both.

and co-productions from lower-middle-income countries (3% of selections) and upper-middle-income countries (13% of selections) was more than four times. Co-productions between countries of different income levels were selected at a similar rate as the latter (14% of selections).

Cross-tabulating the two country variables showed that films from high-income origins were selected for festivals more often regardless of the country's population (Figure 3E). Still, productions from large-population, high-income countries were programed three times more often than films from small-population, high-income countries (15% of selections) and six times more often than co-productions between high-income countries with large and small populations (9% of selections). Films from upper-middle-income countries were selected for festivals at a more substantial rate only when the origin also had a large population (11% of selections versus 1% for small-population, upper-middle-income countries). Similarly, co-productions across income brackets were programed at a considerable rate only when at least one partner had a large population (6% of selections for large-population country co-productions, 7% for co-productions between countries with large and small populations, but only 0.7% for small-population country co-productions across income brackets).

Change in programming selections

Our longitudinal analysis of the Cinando data demonstrated that festivals consistently selected most films and co-productions from large-population countries during 2014–

2021 (63–70% of selections, [Figure 4A](#)). The share of programming selections going to co-productions between countries with small and large populations remained more or less stable over time (13–15% of selections). However, programming selections of films and co-productions from small-population countries increased by 8% during the COVID-19 pandemic, when festivals shifted to online or hybrid formats (De Valck & Damien, 2023; Smits, 2023). Films from high-income countries consistently comprised the majority of festival programming over the period (71–75% of selections, including co-productions between high-income origins, [Figure 4B](#)). Nevertheless, unlike small-population country films, there was no visible improvement in the inclusion of films made in countries with lower income over time.

Examining programming records of our sample festivals by production country's population and income over time revealed consistently better income diversity among films from large-population countries, where productions from high-income origins accounted for only 66–76% of selections, in contrast to 81–90% of selections from small-population, high-income countries ([Figure 4C](#)). The cross-tabulation analysis also detailed that the increased programming selections of films from small-population countries was primarily driven by a better inclusion of productions from high-income countries. In contrast, festival attention to productions from small-population countries across lower income levels continued to be limited during the period.

Programming differences across the festival hierarchy

The longitudinal analysis of the Cinando data by festival group (competitive A-list versus all other festivals in our sample) showed that festival selections of films or co-productions from small-population countries improved only outside the competitive A-list events

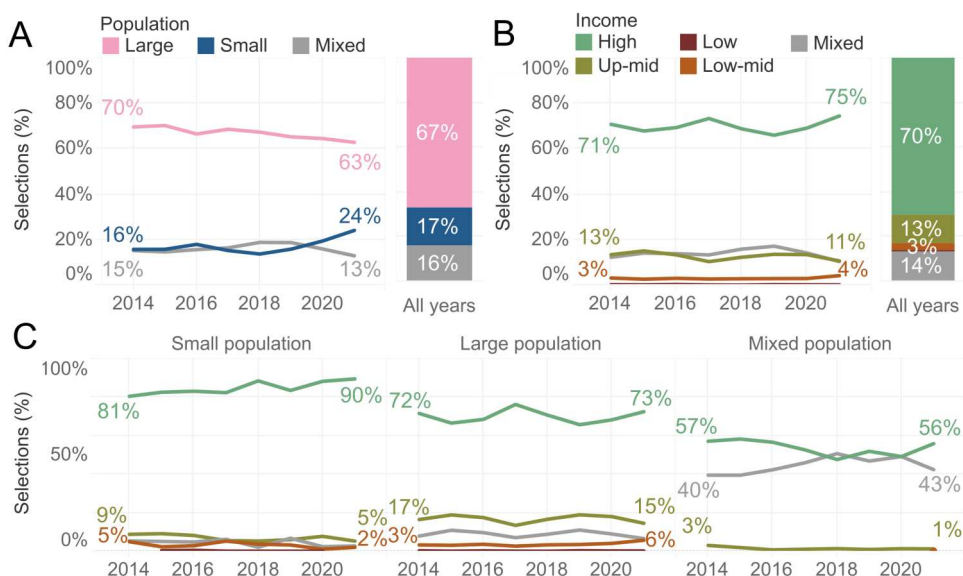


Figure 4. Festival programming change by production origin (2014–2021), by (A) population, (B) income, and (C) both.

during 2014–2021 (10% increase among other events, [Figure 5A](#)). In contrast, the A-list festivals selected films from small-population countries at a steady 14–17% rate for most of the analysis period, before selections suddenly fell by 8% in 2021. Programming selections of co-productions between countries with small and large populations remained more or less stable over time. However, the cross-category collaborations were selected slightly more often at the competitive A-list events (19% of selections) than at other festivals (15% of selections).

The programming of the competitive A-list festivals demonstrated greater income diversity among the featured film production origins, with only 66% of selections going to high-income countries versus an average of 72% in the other events ([Figure 5B](#)). Furthermore, the competitive A-list events decreased their proportion of selections for content from high-income countries by 11% during 2014–2021, while increasing their selections for lower-middle-income films and cross-income-category co-productions. In contrast, high-income origins gained more prominence in the programming of other events during the period (an additional 4% of selections).

The longitudinal cross-tabulation analysis tracking the production country's population size and income in the programming of different festivals further confirmed the

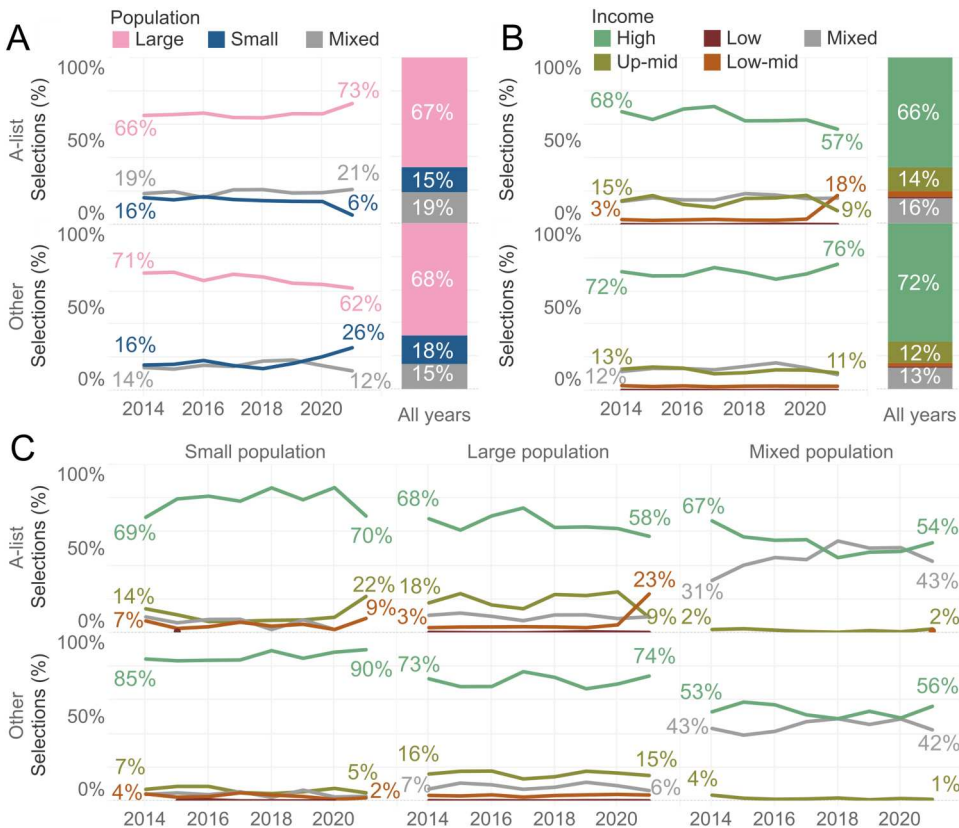


Figure 5. Change in programming of A-list vs. other festivals (2014–2021), by film origin's (A) population, (B) income, and (C) both.

previously noted greater income diversity among films from large-population countries, particularly outside the competitive A-list events (Figure 5C). At the other festivals, 67–77% of the films from large-population countries came from high-income countries, whereas a much higher share (83–90%) of films from small-population countries did so.

Programming of individual festivals

A disaggregate programming analysis showed that when examined individually, most event series from the Cinando data (76% or 94 out of 123) primarily selected films made in large-population countries, which aligns with our aggregate statistics. However, the representation of small-population films increased slightly over the period at three A-list events: Mar del Plata, Cannes, and Tokyo (Figure 6). Nonetheless, the improvement primarily concerned co-productions between countries with small and large populations rather than national films from small-population countries. Some event series from the other group, such as the Buenos Aires International Festival of Independent Cinema (BAFICI), also selected increasingly more co-productions between countries with small and large populations over the period but simultaneously decreased their selections of single-origin films from small-population countries (Figure 6). Conversely, other events like Sundance decreased their focus on large-population country productions in favor of better inclusion of both small-population country films and co-productions between countries with small and large populations.

Further examination of individual festival programs suggested that small-population film origins were better represented at events also held in countries with small populations. Three out of 14 competitive A-list festivals from our sample took place in small

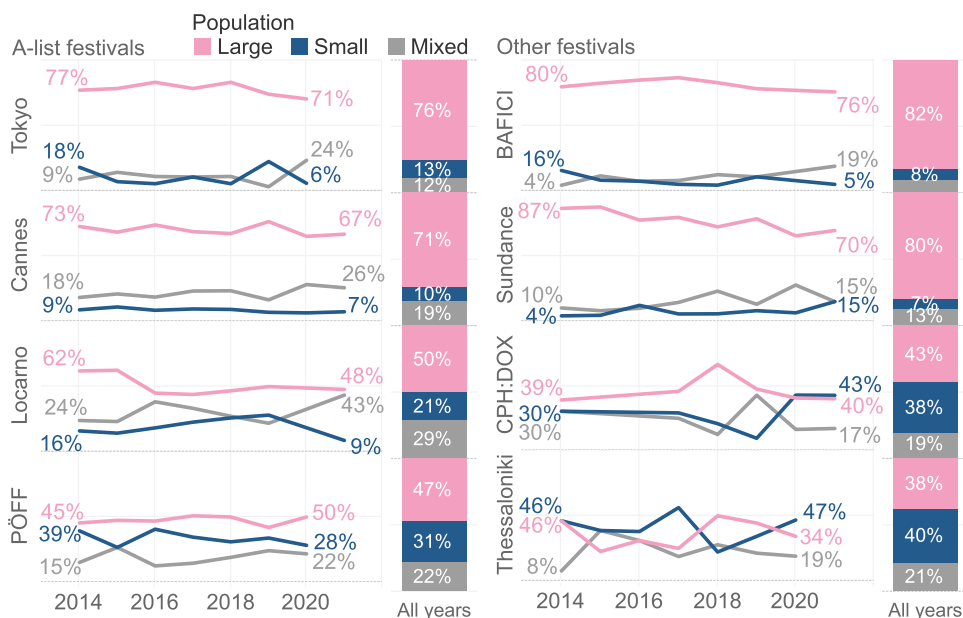


Figure 6. Change in programming by film origin's population (2014–2021) at selected A-list (Tokyo, Cannes, Locarno, and PÖFF) and other events (BAFICI, Sundance, CPH:DOX, and Thessaloniki).

countries: Karlovy Vary (Czechia), Locarno (Switzerland), and Tallinn Black Nights (PÖFF, Estonia). These events consistently selected 50% or more films from small-population countries or co-productions between small and large countries (Figure 6). While co-productions between countries with small and large populations received considerable attention at Locarno, a hefty share of selections at PÖFF went to films or co-productions from small-population countries.

This rule also applied to most festival series in the other group. Namely, 62% of other events organized in small-population countries (18 out of 29) were also more welcoming to small-population films and co-productions between countries with small and large populations (i.e. CPH:DOX, Denmark; Thessaloniki, Greece, Figure 6). But notably, 10% of other festivals held in large-population countries (8 out of 80) had over 50% of selections for small-population country films and for co-productions between countries with small and large populations.

Relationship between production country characteristics and festival selections

Our correlation analysis using base-10 logarithms of all variables showed a significant positive relationship between a country's population and the number of times its films were selected for festivals within our sample based on the Cinando data ($r(162) = .52$, $p < .001$, Figure 7A). An even stronger positive correlation characterized the relationship between a country's GDP and the number of festival selections for its films ($r(162) = .83$, $p < .001$, Figure 7B). These findings suggest that the higher the country's population or economic output, the more festival selections its films typically attract.

The visual examination of the relationship between the two production-country variables and festival selections suggests that films from origins with large GDP and population, like the US, France, and Germany, were selected for festivals in our sample the most (Figure 7C). In contrast, productions from countries with lower GDP, including Tanzania, Pakistan, and Indonesia, were programed less frequently, regardless of their population.

Discussion and conclusion

This article investigated how well film festivals around the world represent films produced in small countries as defined by population and income. Quantitative methods were employed to examine the programming records of the competitive A-list feature film festivals in contrast to all other events organized during 2009–2021 based on the Cinando database.

Our findings indicate that film production origins with large populations and high incomes dominate film festival programming across the world. However, films produced in small-population countries have gained traction in recent years, particularly outside the competitive A-list festivals, which could be considered more thematically specialized (i.e. CPH:DOX, Fantasia) and locally relevant (i.e. Göteborg, Jeonju). Unfortunately, the increased representation did not translate equally across production-country income levels, mainly concerning wealthy small-population countries. Furthermore, films from small-population countries remain poorly represented at the competitive A-list events. This is especially problematic since other festivals tend to replicate programming

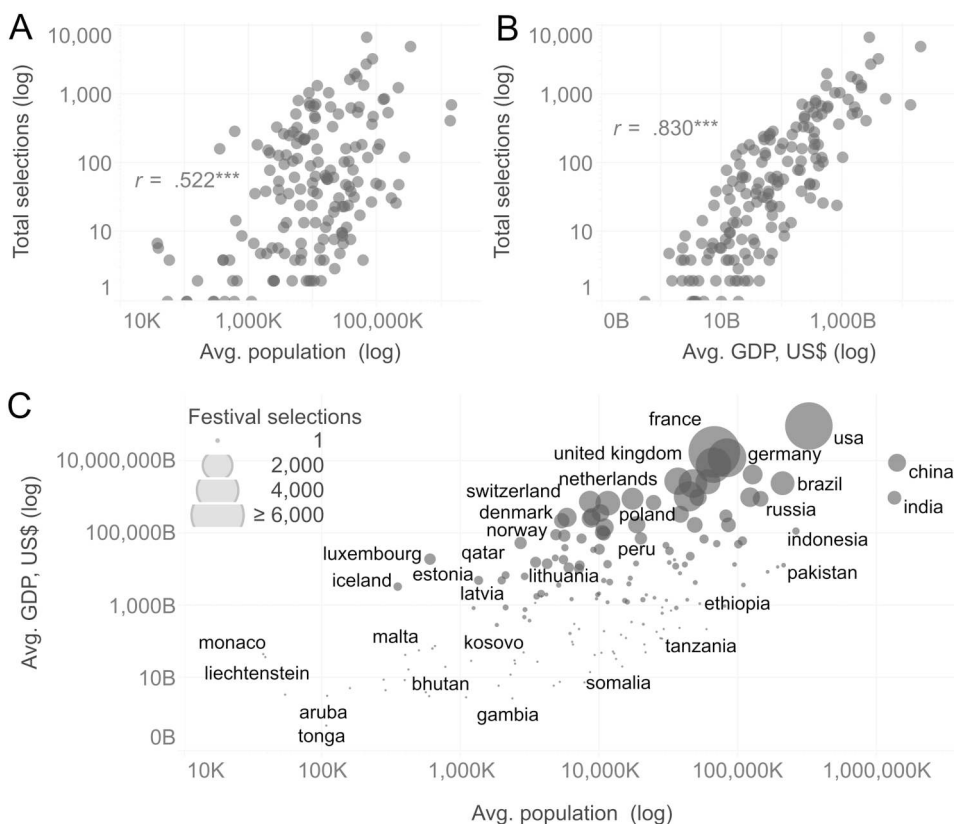


Figure 7. Relationships between festival selections and (A) average yearly population and (B) average yearly GDP (2009–2021). (C) Relationship between average yearly population and GDP, circles sized to total festival selections. Festival selections of co-productions counted toward each country equally. All axes in base-10 logarithmic scale, with bin sizes increasing along axes. Pearson correlation coefficients: * $p < .05$ ** $p < .01$ *** $p < .001$.

choices from high-prestige events, reinforcing visibility hierarchies and contributing to the canonization of particular filmmakers and national cinemas (De Valck, 2007; Nichols, 1994). It remains unclear whether the rise in representation of small-population countries during 2020–2021, when festivals moved online, will persist post-pandemic, as some distributors might have postponed premieres of higher-profile films during that time, viewing online launches as less impactful (De Valck & Damiens, 2023; Smits, 2023). What we do find, however, is that festivals organized in small-population countries appear to be more welcoming to small-population country films. Furthermore, when it comes to the income of film production origins, the competitive A-list festivals demonstrate better programming diversity than other events in our sample, particularly among countries with large populations. Still, the general trend is that the more populous and economically prosperous a production country is, the more likely its films are to be selected for festivals.

This leads us to the main research question addressed through our study: *to what extent can we say that small countries are peripheral in the global film market, expressed by low or non-representation in the programming of film festivals?* Our findings confirm

that smallness does, as a matter of fact, suggest peripherality in terms of the global film festival representation of films from small-population and low-income markets, providing further evidence of the constrained international reach of such films (Hjort, 2007) and the overall peripherality of less populous and less wealthy production countries in the global film industry (Curtin, 2009; Szczepanik, 2021). However, our longitudinal analysis of the Cinando dataset revealed a positive trend in the inclusion of films from small-population countries for festivals. Notably, this improvement primarily pertained to films from small-population countries with high income. Income level emerges as a pivotal determinant of representation in film festivals internationally, affirming the importance of a production country's market size in the global media trade (Chung, 2011; Fu & Sim, 2010; Tunstall, 2008). Our findings indicate minimal programming inclusion of countries at the lowest income level, irrespective of population size. Thus, while population size plays a significant role in assessing a market's peripheral status within the international film festival system, income level acts as a counterbalancing factor for smaller markets.

Our findings should be interpreted against a set of limitations. First, although the data captured events from all continents, most festivals were held in Europe, North America, and Latin America. Broadening the geographical coverage across Asia, Oceania, and Africa (and countries in the Global South more generally) would yield a more complete understanding of the global film festival circuit. Second, years before 2014 could not be considered in the longitudinal analyses due to low data volumes, and the COVID-19 pandemic coincided with the end of the data collection period. Extending the analysis time frame beyond the pandemic years would allow testing whether the observed trends persist. Third, while a country's population and income relate to the size of its media market, film industry workforce, domestic audience spending power, and national film investment, further research could employ more direct measures of national media production capacity, like the number of active production companies or films released each year. Fourth, although we treat national attribution as a meaningful unit of analysis, many films are co-productions involving multinational funding and creative input, which complicates straightforward associations between origin and festival representation. We recommend future research explore these transnational dynamics. Fifth, using the nation-state as the primary unit of analysis may obscure Indigenous and minoritized contributions to film production within larger countries, inadequately representing their cultural outputs through national-level data, suggesting an avenue for further research. Despite these limitations, the Cinando database remains the most comprehensive and globally accessible source of film festival information for quantitatively analyzing the festival circuit on a global and longitudinal scale. Furthermore, our study offers the first large-scale, longitudinal analysis of the representation of small countries in festival programming. We recognize that film festivals are complex cultural institutions shaped by curatorial agency, geopolitical dynamics, and symbolic economies. Future research should complement quantitative analysis with qualitative methods to better capture the layered decision-making processes and power structures. One promising avenue beyond the scope of this study, due to data limitations, is the role of the alternative film festival circuit, including Indigenous and regionally-focused events (i.e., imagineNATIVE, Māoriland, Sámi), within parallel curatorial ecosystems and their intersections with major international events in shaping the visibility and circulation of films from underrepresented production contexts.

The fact that small-population production origins remain at the periphery of the international film festival circuit has serious implications for their national film industries. Failing to enter festivals at the same rate as productions from large-population countries can further constrain the already limited opportunities for international distribution faced by films from less populous markets (Hjort, 2007; Nielsen et al., 2024). Furthermore, being consistently left out of the programming of the main industry events is even more detrimental since they can act as amplifiers of international visibility and shape broader programming trends across the festival network (Burgess, 2020; De Valck, 2007; Nichols, 1994). Therefore, national film policy efforts in small-population countries should be directed toward increasing participation in A-list festivals, as it could have a ripple effect across the wider circuit. Admittedly, this task is not only more important for low-income nations, considering their historical exclusion from such events, but it is also more challenging for them in light of their potential shortage of resources. Further research could investigate how disparities in national film infrastructure (film commissions, public funding, and training institutions) intersect with income levels to affect access to top-tier festivals, and how festivals might better support under-resourced filmmaking contexts through inclusive programming initiatives. Initiating efforts to target major industry events hosted in small-population countries could prove fruitful, as our research has shown they often exhibit a greater openness to productions from small-population sources. The positive effects of festival participation on the national film industry, not only regarding improved creativity and professionalism but also monetary inflow to the local film industry and the country, provide a compelling justification for such prioritization.

Notes

1. Berlin, Cairo, Cannes, Fajr, Goa, Karlovy Vary, Locarno, Mar del Plata, San Sebastian, Shanghai, Tallinn Black Nights, Tokyo, Venice, and Warsaw.
2. Country statistics were missing for six film production origins: Canary Islands, Guadeloupe, Guernsey, North Korea, Taiwan, and Western Sahara.

Acknowledgements

The authors thank Marché du Film – Festival de Cannes for granting access to the Cinando database, as well as Andres Karjus and the Media Industries 2024 conference participants for their valuable comments.

Data availability

Film festival programming data analyzed in this article are available from the Figshare database at <https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.22682794.v1>. Cinando technical IDs have been anonymized. Data on social and economic characteristics of film production countries analyzed in this article are available from the World Bank website at <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/NY.GDP.MKTP.CD> for GDP, <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/SP.POP.TOTL> for population, and <https://datacatalogfiles.worldbank.org/ddh-published/0037712/DR0090754/OGHIST.xlsx> for country classification into lending groups.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

This work was supported by the Estonian Research Council [grant number PRG 1641] and the European Commission [grant number 101094988].

ORCID

Vejune Zemaityte  <http://orcid.org/0000-0001-9714-7903>

Ulrike Rohn  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-1247-904X>

Indrek Ibrus  <http://orcid.org/0000-0003-1524-270X>

References

- Agger, G. (2016). The development of transnationality in Danish noir – from unit one to the team. *Northern Lights: Film & Media Studies Yearbook*, 14(1), 83–101. https://doi.org/10.1386/nl.14.1.83_1
- Baltruschat, D. (2010). *Global media ecologies: Networked production in film and television*. Routledge.
- Bondebjerg, I. (2016). Transnational Europe: TV-drama, co-production networks and mediated cultural encounters. *Palgrave Communications*, 2, Article 16034. <https://doi.org/10.1057/palcomms.2016.34>
- Boyd-Barrett, O. (1977). Media imperialism: Towards an international framework for the analysis of media systems. In M. Gurevitch, J. Curran, & J. Woollacott (Eds.), *Mass communication and society* (pp. 116–135). Edward Arnold.
- Boyd-Barrett, O., & Thussu, D. K. (1992). *Contra-flow in global news: International and regional news exchange mechanisms*. J. Libbey.
- Burgess, D. (2020). Capturing film festival buzz: The methodological dilemma of measuring symbolic value. *NECSUS*, 9(2), 225–247. <https://doi.org/10.25969/mediarep/15318>
- Chung, J. E. (2011). Mapping international film trade: Network analysis of international film trade between 1996 and 2004. *Journal of Communication*, 61(4), 618–640. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1460-2466.2011.01567.x>
- Crane, D. (2018). Cultural flows and the global film industry: A comparison of Asia and Europe as regional cultures. In N. Kawashima, & H. K. Lee (Eds.), *Asian cultural flows: Cultural policies, creative industries, and media consumers* (pp. 113–126). Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-10-0147-5_7.
- Curtin, M. (2007). *Playing to the world's biggest audience: The globalization of Chinese film and TV*. University of California Press.
- Curtin, M. (2009). Thinking globally: From media imperialism to media capital. In J. Holt, & A. Perren (Eds.), *Media industries: History, theory, and method* (pp. 108–119). Wiley-Blackwell.
- Czach, L. (2004). Film festivals, programming, and the building of a national cinema. *Moving Image*, 4(1), 76–88. <https://doi.org/10.1353/mov.2004.0004>
- [dataset] World Bank. (2022). World development indicators and classification datasets: *GDP, population, and country and lending groups*. Retrieved August 22, 2023, from <https://data.worldbank.org>.
- DeFillippi, R. J., & Arthur, M. B. (1998). Paradox in project-based enterprise: The case of film making. *California Management Review*, 40(2), 125–139. <https://doi.org/10.2307/41165936>
- De Valck, M. (2007). *Film festivals: From European geopolitics to global cinephilia*. Amsterdam University Press. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt46mv45>.
- De Valck, M., & Damians, A. eds. (2023). *Rethinking film festivals in the pandemic era and after*. Palgrave. <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-14171-3>.

- Dunleavy, P. (2016). Crossing new boundaries in public TV drama: The transnational success of Denmark's *Forbrydelsen*. In G. Ferrell Lowe, & N. Yamamoto (Eds.), *Crossing borders and boundaries in public service media* (pp. 201–214). Nordicom.
- FIAPF. (2023). *Accredited festivals*. Retrieved September 1, 2023, from <https://fiapf.org/festivals/accredited-festivals/competitive-feature-film-festivals/>.
- Fong, S. Y., & Ng, H. W. (2020). Unpacking the 'Singapore New Wave'. *Asian Cinema*, 31(1), 3–15. https://doi.org/10.1386/ac_00010_2
- Frater, P. (2007, June 17). *Gilmore speaks out against FIAPF*. Variety. <https://variety.com/2007/film/asia/gilmore-speaks-out-against-fiapf-1117967083/>.
- Fu, W. W., & Sim, C. (2010). Examining international country-to-country flow of theatrical films. *Journal of Communication*, 60(1), 120–143. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1460-2466.2009.01455.x>
- Goldstein-Gidoni, O. (2005). The production and consumption of 'Japanese culture' in the global cultural market. *Journal of Consumer Culture*, 5(2), 155–179. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1469540505053092>
- Hansen, K. T., & Waade, A. M. (2017). *Locating Nordic Noir: From Beck to The Bridge*. Palgrave. <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-59815-4>.
- Harbord, J. (2002). *Film cultures*. Sage. <https://doi.org/10.4135/9781446219591>.
- Hjort, M. (2007). *Cinema of small nations*. Edinburgh University Press.
- Hjort, M. (2015). The risk environment of small-nation filmmaking. In J. Blankenship, & T. Nagl (Eds.), *European visions: Small cinemas in transition* (pp. 49–64). Transcript. <https://doi.org/10.1515/9783839418185-003>.
- Hoskins, C., & Mirus, R. (1988). Reasons for the US dominance of the international trade in television programmes. *Media, Culture & Society*, 10(4), 499–515. <https://doi.org/10.1177/016344388010004006>
- Ibrus, I. (2016). The EU digital single market as a mission impossible: Audio-visual policy conflicts for Estonia. *International Journal of Digital Television*, 7(1), 23–38. https://doi.org/10.1386/jdvtv.7.1.23_1
- Ibrus, I., & Rohn, U. (2019). Small size matters: Audiovisual media industries around the Baltic Sea. In I. Ibrus (Ed.), *Emergence of cross-innovation systems* (pp. 41–58). Emerald Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.1108/978-1-78769-977-920191009>.
- Iordanova, D. (2009). The film festival circuit. In D. Iordanova, & R. Rhyne (Eds.), *Film festival yearbook 1: The festival circuit* Vol. 1 (pp. 23–39). Wallflower.
- Jäckel, A. (2003). *European film industries*. British Film Institute.
- Jensen, P. M., & Jacobsen, U. C. (2017). Danish TV drama: Behind the unexpected popularity. *Critical Studies in Television*, 12(4), 325–330. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1749602017733562>
- Jensen, P. M., Nielsen, J. I., & Waade, A. M. (2016). When public service drama travels: The internationalization of Danish television drama and the associated production funding models. *Journal of Popular Television*, 4(1), 91–108. https://doi.org/10.1386/jptv.4.1.91_1
- Jin, D. Y. (2017). Digital platform as a double-edged sword: How to interpret cultural flows in the platform era. *International Journal of Communication*, 11, 3880–3898. <https://ijoc.org/index.php/ijoc/article/view/6201>.
- Kanzler, M. (2023). *An analysis of European box office structure 2010–2022*. European Audiovisual Observatory (EAO). <https://rm.coe.int/analysis-of-european-box-office-structure-2010-2022-december-2023-m-ka/1680ad9268>.
- Kraidy, M. M. (2005). *Hybridity, or the cultural logic of globalization*. Temple University Press.
- Krainhöfer, T. C. (2018). *Mapping of collaboration models among film festivals: A qualitative analysis to identify and assess collaboration models in the context of the multiple functions and objectives of film festivals*. European Commission. <https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/library/mapping-collaboration-models-among-film-festivals>.
- Krings, M., & Okome, O. (2013). *Global Nollywood: The transnational dimensions of an African video film industry*. Indiana University Press.
- Lacourt, A., Munch, E., Radel-Cormann, J., & AVMSDigest (2023). *The promotion of European works*. EAO. <https://www.vaf.be/files/Onderzoek/AVMSDigest-The-promotion-of-European-works.pdf>.

- Leotta, A. (2015). Small nations and the global dispersal of film production: A comparative analysis of the film industries in New Zealand and the United Arab Emirates. *Political Economy of Communication*, 2(2), 20–35. <https://www.polecom.org/index.php/polecom/article/view/36/234>.
- Lobato, R. (2018). *Netflix nations: The geography of digital distribution*. New York University Press. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctv12pnnk3>.
- Loist, S. (2016). The film festival circuit: Networks, hierarchies, and circulation. In M. De Valck, B. Kredell, & S. Loist (Eds.), *Film festivals: History, theory, method, practice* (pp. 49–64). Routledge. <https://www.taylorfrancis.com/chapters/edit/10.43249781315637167-6/film-festival-circuit-skadi-loist>.
- Loist, S. (2023). Studying film circulation: Moving film festival research to an evidence-based, global perspective. In D. Ostrowska, & T. Falicov (Eds.), *Film festivals research and methodologies: Dialogues between film festival scholars and practitioners*. Amsterdam University Press.
- Loist, S., & Samoilova, Z. (2019, October 29). *Getting started on the Film Circulation Project: Studying film festivals with various data sources*. Film Circulation. www.filmcirculation.net/2019/10/29/getting-started-on-the-film-circulation-project/.
- Loist, S., & Samoilova, Z. (2023). How to capture the festival network: Reflections on the film circulation dataset. *NECSUS*, 12(1), 363–390. <https://doi.org/10.25969/mediarep/19615>
- Lowe, G. F., Berg, C. E., & Nissen, C. S. (2011). Size matters for TV broadcasting policy. In G. F. Lowe, & C. S. Nissen (Eds.), *Small among giants: Television broadcasting in smaller countries* (pp. 21–42). Nordicom.
- MacPherson, R. (2011, October 6). *Film success in small countries – from Scotland to Singapore*. Culture360. <https://culture360.asef.org/insights/film-success-small-countries-scotland-singapore/>.
- Michalis, M. (2014). Focal points of European media policy from inception till present: Plus Ça change? In K. Donders, C. Pauwels, & J. Loisen (Eds.), *Palgrave handbook on European media policy* (pp. 128–142). Palgrave. https://doi.org/10.1057/9781137032195_8.
- Mirrlees, T. (2013). *Global entertainment media: Between cultural imperialism and cultural globalization*. Routledge.
- Murray, J. (2015). *The new Scottish cinema*. I.B. Tauris.
- Nagib, L., Perriam, C., & Dudrah, R. (2012). *Theorizing world cinema*. I.B. Tauris.
- Nichols, B. (1994). Discovering form, inferring meaning: New cinemas and the film festival circuit. In T. Elsaesser (Ed.), *European cinema: Face to face with Hollywood* (pp. 212–222). Amsterdam University Press.
- Nielsen, J. I., Bengesser, C., Øfsti, M., Kostovska, I., Rohn, U., Falcon, A., Primorac, J., Ibrus, I., Raats, T., Hammoud, P., Pernin, J., Muller, F., Flanagan, N., Trehy, P., Muirthile, R. O., Matulis, R., Kiaupaite, R., Kreivienė, K., & Graça, A. R. (2024). *Small European film markets: Portraits and comparisons*. CresCine project. <https://www.crescine.eu/small-film-industries>.
- Nordenstreng, K., & Varis, T. (1974). *Television traffic: A one-way street? A survey and analysis of the international flow of television programme material*. UNESCO. <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000007560>.
- Palis, J. (2015). Film festivals, the globalisation of images and post-national cinephilia. *Pennsylvania Geographer*, 53(2), 35–47.
- Parc, J. (2020). Understanding film co-production in the era of globalization: A value chain approach. *Global Policy*, 11(4), 458–465. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1758-5899.12830>
- Peirano, M. P. (2017). Film mobilities and circulation practices in the construction of recent Chilean cinema. In A. Kjaerulff, S. Kesselring, P. Peters, & K. Hannam (Eds.), *Envisioning networked urban mobilities: Art, performances, impacts* (pp. 135–147). Routledge. <https://www.taylorfrancis.com/chapters/edit/10.43249781315200217-13/film-mobilities-circulation-practices-construction-recent-chilean-cinema-mar%C3%ADa-paz-peirano>.
- Pelinka, A. (2005). *Vergleich politischer Systeme*. Böhlau.
- Puppis, M. (2009). Media regulation in small states. *International Communication Gazette*, 71(1–2), 7–17. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1748048508097927>
- Rawle, S. (2018). *Transnational cinema: An introduction*. Bloomsbury.
- Redvall, E. N. (2018). International co-production of Nordic television drama: The case of Ride Upon the Storm. In J. Hammett-Jamart, P. Mitric, & E. N. Redvall (Eds.), *European film and television*

- co-production: *Policy and practice* (pp. 137–152). Palgrave. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-97157-5_8.
- Rohn, U. (2009). *Cultural barriers to the success of foreign media content: Western media in China, India, and Japan*. Peter Lang.
- Rohn, U. (2011). Lacuna or universal? Introducing a new model for understanding cross-cultural audience demand. *Media, Culture & Society*, 33(4), 631–641. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0163443711399223>
- Rohn, U. (2014). Small market, big format: Idols in Estonia. *Baltic Screen Media Review*, 2(1), 122–137. <https://doi.org/10.1515/bsmr-2015-0018>
- Rohn, U., & Loeser, H. (2020). Policy alignment in the European audio-visual sector: A small-market perspective from Estonia. *Journal of Digital Media & Policy*, 11(1), 7–28. https://doi.org/10.1386/jdmp_00009_1
- Rohn, U., Loeser, H., & Järvekülg, M. (2018, May 6–9). *Internationally networked film production: The value of support mechanisms for a pan-European production market from the perspective of a small country*. World media economics and management conference, Cape Town, South Africa.
- Roxborough, S. (2020, February 16). *Berlin rebooted: Festival shuffles lineup, aims for recharged market*. Hollywood Reporter. <https://www.hollywoodreporter.com/movies/movie-news/berlin-rebooted-festival-shuffles-lineup-aims-recharged-market-1278615/>.
- Rüling, C. C., & Pedersen, J. (2010). Film festival research from an organizational studies perspective. *Scandinavian Journal of Management*, 26(3), 318–323. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.scaman.2010.06.006>
- Šavk, S. (2024). Borrowed soundtracks: Adopting the global history approach to the study of connectedness in film history. *Continuum*, 1–13. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10304312.2024.2343857>
- Smits, R. (2023). Disruption in times of COVID-19? The hybrid film festival format. *Cultural Trends*, 33(3), 309–323. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09548963.2023.2193872>
- Straubhaar, J. D. (1991). Beyond media imperialism: Asymmetrical interdependence and cultural proximity. *Critical Studies in Media Communication*, 8(1), 39–59. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15295039109366779>
- Straubhaar, J. D. (2007). *World television: From global to local*. Sage. <https://doi.org/10.4135/9781452204147>.
- Stringer, J. (2001). Global cities and the international film festival economy. In M. Shiel, & T. Fitzmaurice (Eds.), *Cinema and the city: Film and urban societies in a global context* (pp. 134–144). Blackwell. <https://doi.org/10.1002/9780470712948.ch11>.
- Sun, Y. (2015). Shaping Hong Kong cinema's new icon: Milkyway image at international film festivals. *Transnational Cinemas*, 6(1), 67–83. <https://doi.org/10.1080/20403526.2014.1002671>
- Szczepanik, P. (2021). *Screen industries in East-Central Europe*. Bloomsbury.
- Talavera, J. (2017). *Film production in Europe – production volume, co-production and worldwide circulation*. EAO. <https://rm.coe.int/filmproductionineurope-2017-j-talavera-pdf/1680788952>.
- Thompson, K., & Bordwell, D. (1994). *Film history: An introduction*. McGraw-Hill.
- Thussu, D. K. (2006). *Media on the move: Global flow and contra-flow*. Routledge.
- Trappel, J. (2014). Small states and European media policy. In K. Donders, C. Pauwels, & J. Loisen (Eds.), *The Palgrave handbook of European media policy* (pp. 239–253). Palgrave. https://doi.org/10.1057/9781137032195_14.
- Tunstall, J. (2008). *The media were American: U.S. Mass media in decline*. Oxford University Press.
- UNESCO. (2005). Convention on the protection and promotion of the diversity of cultural expressions. <https://www.unesco.org/creativity/en/2005-convention>.
- Vallejo, A. (2015). Documentary filmmakers on the circuit: A festival career from Czech Dream to Czech Peace. In C. Deprez, & J. Pernin (Eds.), *Post-1990 documentary: Reconfiguring independence* (pp. 171–187). Edinburgh University Press. <https://doi.org/10.3366/edinburgh/9780748694136.003.0012>.
- Vallejo, A. (2020). Rethinking the canon: The role of film festivals in shaping film history. *Studies in European Cinema*, 17(2), 155–169. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17411548.2020.1765631>

- Winseck, D. (2011). The political economies of media and the transformation of the global media industries. In D. Winseck, & D. Yong Jin (Eds.), *The political economies of media: The transformation of the global media industries* (pp. 3–48). Bloomsbury.
- Wong, C. H. Y. (2011). *Film festivals: Culture, people, and power on the global screen*. Rutgers University Press. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt5hjg83>.
- World Bank. (n.d.). *The World Bank Atlas method – detailed methodology*. Retrieved August 22, 2023, from <https://datahelpdesk.worldbank.org/knowledgebase/articles/378832-what-is-the-world-bank-atlas-method>.
- Zemaityte, V., Karjus, A., Rohn, U., Schich, M., & Ibrus, I. (2023). *Cinando film festival programming dataset*. Figshare. <https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.22682794.v1>.
- [dataset] Zemaityte, V., Karjus, A., Rohn, U., Schich, M., & Ibrus, I. (2024). Quantifying the global film festival circuit: Networks, diversity, and public value creation. *PLoS One*, 19(3), Article e0297404. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0297404>